

Unit 2 Project Planning Organizer

Names (first and last): Shiven Swami, Yash Patil, Jonah Luo, Drew Dupart

Book Title: The Namesake

Author: Jhumpa Lahiri

STEP 1: FORMAT SELECTION & VISION

Choose your format: *(Circle/highlight one)*

- ☐ Podcast/Talk Show
- ☐ Video Essay (YouTube Style)
- ☒ **Interactive Digital Story**
- ☐ Documentary Film

Our creative vision in one sentence: “The Namesake Line” is an animated website where a steam train carries the audience through Gogol Ganguli’s life from 1961 to 2000, stopping at 15 “stations” that combine the story, our 4 I’s analysis, and short videos of us acting out key scenes.

Target audience: Teens who are children of immigrants or who feel caught between two cultures; anyone whose name gets mispronounced or who has been told to “just pick an easier name”; and teachers looking for ways to talk about identity and assimilation.

Our “hook” ideas:

- **The Overcoat opening:** the site starts on a closed wool overcoat (a nod to Gogol’s story “The Overcoat”). Visitors write their name on a “HELLO my name is” tag, then the coat swings open and the train pulls in.
- **Rewind to the crash:** at Gogol’s birth, a “Why ‘Gogol’?” button rewinds the train to 1961, and the train crash plays out in black and white.
- **Live class question:** “Raise your hand if you’ve ever gone by a different name at school.”
- **Personal ending:** the finale asks each visitor by name, “Who gave you your name?”

STEP 2: CORE ANALYSIS FRAMEWORK

A. The System Exposed

What is the main system of bias/oppression your book reveals? Pressure on immigrant families to assimilate. American culture pushes immigrants and their children to shrink or erase their names, language, and traditions to fit in. It rarely looks like open hostility. It shows up as institutions that don’t make room for other cultures, casual stereotypes, and the shame kids like Gogol learn to feel about their own heritage.

Key evidence from the text:

Quote/Example 1: “Being a foreigner, Ashima is beginning to realize, is a sort of lifelong pregnancy—a perpetual wait, a constant burden, a continuous feeling of out of sorts” (Lahiri, p. ____). This shows the isolation and pressure immigrant parents live with.

Quote/Example 2: The hospital won’t discharge baby Gogol without a name on the birth certificate, even though by Bengali custom his great-grandmother is supposed to choose his “good name” and her

letter is still in the mail. That American rule is the only reason “Gogol” becomes his official name (p. ____).

Quote/Example 3: Before college, Gogol legally changes his name to “Nikhil.” Afterward he feels like he is pretending, living as two people. The name change is the book’s biggest symbol of assimilation (p. ____).

B. The 4 I’s of Oppression Analysis

IDEOLOGICAL (*beliefs/stereotypes that justify oppression*)

How it appears in your book: The belief that “American” means white and that anyone Indian is a permanent outsider. At the Ratliffs’ lake house, a dinner guest assumes Gogol must never get sick in India because he’s “Indian,” and he has to point out that he grew up in Massachusetts (p. ____).

Real-world connection: Asian Americans are regularly asked “Where are you really from?”, the “perpetual foreigner” stereotype.

INSTITUTIONAL (*laws, policies, organizational practices*)

How it appears in your book: The hospital’s birth-certificate rule forces a name on Gogol. At kindergarten, the principal overrules his parents’ plan to call him “Nikhil,” so the school ends up deciding his name. Later he needs a court process to change his legal name.

Real-world connection: Hiring studies show résumés with non-white-sounding names get fewer callbacks, so many immigrants use anglicized names on job applications.

INTERPERSONAL (*individual actions between people*)

How it appears in your book: Kids tease Gogol about his name, the family’s mailbox is vandalized in a way that mocks their name, and an English teacher’s lesson on Nikolai Gogol’s strange life humiliates him in front of the class.

Real-world connection: Teachers and classmates mispronounce or “nickname” students’ names. Kohli & Solórzano (2012), “Teachers, please learn our names!”, found this affects how students see themselves.

INTERNALIZED (*when oppressed groups believe negative messages about themselves*)

How it appears in your book: Gogol is embarrassed by his name, his parents’ accents, and Bengali traditions. He changes his name, hides parts of himself around Maxine, and feels more at home with her family than his own. Moushumi pushes away her Bengali background in a similar way.

Real-world connection: Children of immigrants often describe feeling “too American for home, too foreign for America,” and some refuse to speak their parents’ language.

C. Breaking Point Analysis

When does trauma/tension peak for your protagonist?

Specific scene/moment: Ashoke’s death. Gogol gets the call that his father died suddenly of a heart attack in Cleveland. He flies there alone, identifies his father, and clears out the apartment.

Why this is the climax: Everything Gogol pushed away (his father, his name, his family’s traditions) suddenly can’t be taken back. He never read the book his father gave him, and the only person who knew the full story behind “Gogol” is gone. The conflict between his two identities peaks here.

Emotional impact on character: Guilt and grief. Gogol shaves his head as part of Bengali mourning, the first tradition he chooses for himself. He moves back toward his mother and sister and pulls away from Maxine, whose world suddenly feels like it has no room for his grief.

D. Resistance & Revolution

How do characters fight back and/or find healing?

Individual actions: At the end, Gogol finally opens *The Short Stories of Nikolai Gogol*, reads his father's inscription ("The man who gave you his name, from the man who gave you your name"), and starts reading. He stops choosing between his two names. Ashima decides to split her year between India and America instead of picking one.

Community responses: The Bengali immigrant community acts as a stand-in family. Its members hold rice ceremonies, pujos, and holiday parties together, and they gather around Ashima after Ashoke dies. They keep their culture alive for each other in a new country.

Systemic changes (if any): Almost none in the book. The institutions stay the same and the characters adapt, so the healing is personal, not systemic. In real life, schools and workplaces increasingly offer name-pronunciation tools and "say my name right" campaigns.

E. Mirror to Society

What does this story reveal about our current world?

Connection to historical event (include researched source): The Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 (Hart-Celler Act) ended the quotas that had nearly shut out Asian immigrants. That opened the door for educated professionals like Ashoke, who settles in the U.S. just a few years later. Source:

Connection to current event (include researched source): Studies that send out identical résumés with different names find fewer callbacks for non-white names, so some immigrants still anglicize their names to get interviews. Source: _____

What it shows about human nature: People want to belong so badly they'll hide parts of themselves to fit in. We often understand our parents only after it's too late to tell them.

Warning or hope for the future: Both. The warning: when society pressures people to erase where they come from, families lose connection across generations. The hope: Gogol shows it's never too late to accept your whole self. You don't have to choose between two cultures to belong.

STEP 3: CREATIVE ELEMENTS PLANNING (Pick 1)

Soundtrack - List 5 songs that reflect the emotional journey: *(bonus)*

1. "Yeh Jo Des Hai Tera" by A.R. Rahman: Ashima's homesickness for India
2. "Who Are You" by The Who: Gogol becoming "Nikhil"
3. "Father and Son" by Cat Stevens: the car ride when Ashoke tells the truth
4. "Fix You" by Coldplay: Ashoke's death and the family's grief
5. "Home" by Phillip Phillips: Gogol accepting who he is

Visual Aesthetic - Describe your color scheme, fonts, logo ideas: *(bonus)*

Night-sky indigo background; saffron orange for Gogol and sky blue for Nikhil (they also color the train track); purple at the end when he is both; maroon Indian-railway train cars; cream "ticket paper" cards. Flashbacks are black and white. Fonts: Rozha One (titles), Spectral (story text), Courier Prime (typewriter-style tickets and stamps). Logo: a rubber ticket stamp with a station code and year (like "CAM 1968") and a "HELLO my name is" name tag.

☑ **Interactive Component** - What will audience participate in: (*our main pick*)

- **Ride the timeline:** move the train with arrow keys, a clicker, or by clicking any of the 15 stations (1961–2000).
- **Station tickets:** each stop opens a card with a Story tab and a 4 I's analysis tab. Four key stations also have a Scene tab with our acted video.
- **Gogol ⇌ Nikhil switch:** locked until 1986, when a "PETITION GRANTED" stamp appears. Flipping it changes each card's "inner voice" between Gogol's and Nikhil's view. The track glows orange for Gogol and blue for Nikhil, and braids together at the end.
- **The lost letter:** an envelope (the letter with his "good name" that never arrived) drifts across the sky and can be clicked.
- **Class votes:** at three stations the class votes by raising hands (e.g., "Would you change your name to fit in?"), then we reveal what Gogol did.
- **Unlockable ending:** after every station is visited, the book opens, the inscription writes itself out, and the site asks the visitor by name, "Who gave you your name?"

STEP 4: COLLABORATION PLANNING

Roles & Responsibilities

Name	Role(s)/Responsibilities
Yash Patil	Web developer: runs the timeline website, adds our videos, edits station text, publishes it on GitHub Pages, and runs the site during the presentation.
Shiven Swami	Director / video editor: films and edits the 4 short scene videos (train crash, kindergarten, the truth in the car, the finale).
Jonah Luo	Script & analysis lead: writes the short scene scripts, checks quotes and adds page numbers, and makes sure the 4 I's analysis matches the book.
Drew Dupart	Research & design lead: finds and cites the historical and current-event sources, gathers props, and runs the class votes during the presentation.
Everyone	Acting in the scenes, testing the website, and presenting.

STEP 5: TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

Equipment/Software Needed:

Recording equipment (phone, computer mic, etc.): Phones for filming (landscape) with the built-in mic; a flashlight for the train-crash scene; a phone speaker for train sound effects. **Props:** a paperback "Gogol" book, a name tag, and two chairs for the train compartment.

Editing software: CapCut or iMovie (free), exported as MP4 so the videos play on the website.

Visual creation tools: Our website, built with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript (animated canvas graphics) in VS Code; Canva for any extra graphics.

Other: GitHub to store the project and GitHub Pages to host the website for free; a laptop plus a projector and a presentation clicker; a shared Google Drive folder for scripts and footage.